Postinvasion, Acheson had hoped that, at the very least, India would participate in proposed UN action on Tibet—seen as having a propaganda purpose. The exercise might lead Delhi to realize how difficult it was to deal with Beijing and Moscow. This could make India "less neutral and more realistic about Communism," facilitating better US-India relations.[178] But, despite indicating that it would participate,[179] India demurred after receiving the more conciliatory note from Beijing and interpreting other Chinese steps as friendlier (e.g., release of some American prisoners of war in North Korea).[180] Bajpai was "suspicious and cynical" about the note, but he agreed that a UN debate would not be helpful at that time.[181] It would jeopardize simultaneous Indian efforts for a ceasefire in Korea.[182] Patel's death in December 1950 only made Nehru's voice more dominant on Tibet. By January 1951, Bajpai was telling Henderson that with Tibet likely beyond saving and other issues intervening, India was "giving little thought to Tibet."[183]

Henderson, who had previously detected little Indian interest in the State Department idea of joint US-UK-India action to stall China in Tibet,[184] urged UN action that could highlight China's "aggressive attitude." But he found Indian assessments to be "wishfully warped" to fit their "inclination to do nothing which might offend China."[185] While some US officials argued that such joint support would buoy Tibetan spirits, Indian officials made clear their belief that the Tibetans were merely trying to postpone—rather than resist—a Chinese takeover.

Indian officials were not disinterested, but they had different moves in mind. They were, in fact, chagrined about the idea of China taking over Tibetan border defense.[186] Bajpai acknowledged that the Sino-Tibetan agreement signed in May 1951 would affect India's position vis-à-vis Bhutan, Burma, Nepal, and even Korea. Delhi had already taken some steps to protect its interests. It had devised its own version of what came to be called pactomania in the Eisenhower administration in the US. It signed treaties with neighbors Bhutan (1949), Nepal (1950), and Sikkim (1950, making it a protectorate) that gave Delhi a crucial say in their foreign and security policies.

There was also an effort to strengthen and integrate India's northeast. After China's initial invasion of Tibet, a defense committee assessed the impact of losing the buffer state. It recommended strengthening border